Regulations

U18 Inter Counties Tournament 2026

Changes / additions from 2025 are marked in red

Format

1. A Tie is the competition between two counties, which will comprise 10 matches: 2 x Open Singles, 2 x Girls Singles, 2 x Open Doubles, 2 x Girls Doubles and 2 x Mixed Doubles.
2. Each player is restricted to a maximum of two matches per tie; these matches must be in different disciplines (e.g. cannot play in both mixed doubles).
3. Players cannot play both singles and mixed doubles in the same match.
4. A Match will be best of 3 games to 15 rally points. At 14-all matches will be played sudden death to 15 points. Players will change ends after each game and, where a match goes to a third game, at the mid-point of that third game.

Team

5. Players must be a member of Badminton England (players not living in England must be registered as a non-resident member), and all players must have a current and valid Compete licence.
6. Players must be eligible to represent their county under the Badminton England County Competition Eligibility Regulations. Copy available from competition@badmintonengland.co.uk.
7. Players must be born on or after 1st January, 2009.
8. The Team shall comprise no more than 10 players five of whom must be nominated to play in the open events and five in the girls events. You can bring as many eligible players as you choose subject to the stipulation that not more than five different players in both the open and girls events represent the team throughout the whole event (i.e. if you have a player whose fitness is suspect, you can delay making the final decision until the last minute).
9. Players eligible for both female and open categories, must be nominated for one category in which they can be selected for throughout the event. Within level doubles, partners must be of the same birth sex. Within mixed doubles, partners must be of different birth sex.
10. Team changes can be made up until start of play on the first day, so you can denominate and re-nominate another player.
11. The composition of the team must be given to the Hall Manager at least 20 minutes before the scheduled time of the tie.

Draw

12. There will be three rounds of competition:
    - 12.1. In the first round counties will be divided into groups and each county will play all others in the same group.
    - 12.2. In the second round new groups will be formed depending on the position achieved by the counties in their first round ties (e.g. those placed first or second in the group

will form new groups in the top half; those placed third or fourth will join others in the lower half).

12.3. In the third round counties compete in their final groups to determine their overall position.

13. The ranking/seeding of teams for the purposes of making the draw, shall be done based on the most recent Badminton England player grades and the February national rankings.

13.1. An aggregated grading score is calculated for each squad across all three disciplines, based upon the players nominated for each team at the time of entry. Where two teams have identical grading scores and this could influence ranking / seeding group allocation, an aggregated ranking score is then used as the secondary metric.

13.2. Non-English County teams ranking / seeding groups will be determined by the Referee and one other nominated member of the ICT Management Committee. The player review shall be based on available evidence to allocate a provisional 'grade' for each player, which is used in the same way to calculate an aggregated grading score for the team, using all or several of the following in no weighted order:

- Head-to-head results against English players through official domestic and international results on BE / BWF /BEC tournament software.
- Their own national gradings and rankings system, and underlying tournaments.
- Information provided directly by the team including:
- Comparative player strength across disciplines
- Other results that provide indicative level against known English players
- Finishing position at major junior international tournaments, European / World Championships, or other significant results or performances.
- BWF / BEC International Rankings may be used and compared with English players, where players have sufficient results to make these reflective of their level.

14. The number of seeds is equal to the number of Round 1 groups. Teams are placed into one of three Ranking Bands based on the Round 1 group structure.

- Ranking Band 1 - covers the teams in seeded positions, which are distributed according to the General Regulations for Tournaments.
- Ranking Band 2 - the number of teams is twice the number of groups randomly distributed across group positions 2 & 3.
- Ranking Band 3 - the remaining teams are randomly distributed across the remaining group positions.

15. The Committee reserves the right to adjust this format if the size of entry warrants it, but any such change will be notified to counties in advance of the event.

Player Order

16. The most recent Badminton England player grades and the March national rankings will be used to determine the playing strength order of singles, doubles, and mixed doubles.
    16.1. Firstly player grade shall be used to determine strength, followed by player ranking.
    16.2. Based on the players grade and ranking within each event.
    16.3. In doubles events the combined player grade and national ranking will be used.
17. Non-English County teams ranking order will be determined by the Referee, based on the player review in regulation 13.
18. If a team plays a player or pair out of order, one match will be awarded to their opponents 15-0,15-0, this to be the 'second' match in the relevant discipline (e.g. Second Open Singles; Second Girls Doubles etc…).

Substitutions

19. Substitutions in a Tie are permitted if a player becomes incapacitated after play has begun, subject to:
    19.1. The Hall Manager agreeing that any such substitution does not contravene the Tournament rules.
    19.2. The Manager of the opposing team being notified of the substitution.

Tie and Group Orders

20. Tie and Group Winners will be determined using the following criteria:

    20.1. Tie:
    - The County that wins the most matches
    - The County that has the best games difference (games won minus games lost)
    - The County that has the best points difference (points won minus points lost)
    - The County that wins the majority of the first rubbers; 1OS, 1GS, 1OD, 1GD, 1XD.

    20.2. Group:
    - The County that wins the most ties
    - The County that wins the most matches
    - The County that has the best games difference (games won minus games lost)
    - The County that has the best points difference (points won minus points lost)
    - The winner in each tie between the two otherwise equal Counties

General

21. Intervals (to enable players to take a drink and towel down), may be taken when the leading score reaches 8 points and between games. The '8 point interval' must not exceed one

minute and the interval between games must not exceed two minutes. At all other times play must be continuous.

22. Coaching/advice:
    22.1. Coaching may be given to players before the match starts and between games, but not at mid-game intervals. The match is deemed to have started when the players have made their way to court and started their on-court warm-up.
    22.2. On-court coaching/advice between games should be made by one person nominated by the Team Manager for each match (and only one such person per team may be on each court at any time.)
    22.3. Coaching between points from behind the court in the designated coaching chair is permitted.
    22.4. Coaching must not disrupt play.
23. Knocking up-players must be ready to play when called. Knocking-up will be limited to 2 minutes before each match; players must not leave the court between the knock-up and the start of the match.
24. Order of Play will be Mixed Doubles, Open Singles, Girls Singles, Open Doubles, Girls Doubles. Ensure your Mixed Doubles pairs are warmed up and ready to start first. In exceptional circumstances this may be changed at the discretion of the Hall Manager, but must be notified to Team Managers to allow players a 2 minutes knock-up time.
25. Shuttles – Babolat Feather Shuttlecocks will be used. The referee and / or the Hall Managers will determine the speed of the shuttlecock. Once the speed has been agreed, no interference with that speed will be accepted.
26. The management group retain the right alter or modify the format or programme in any way it sees fit if it is in the interest of the tournament.

The Referee's decision in all matters is final.